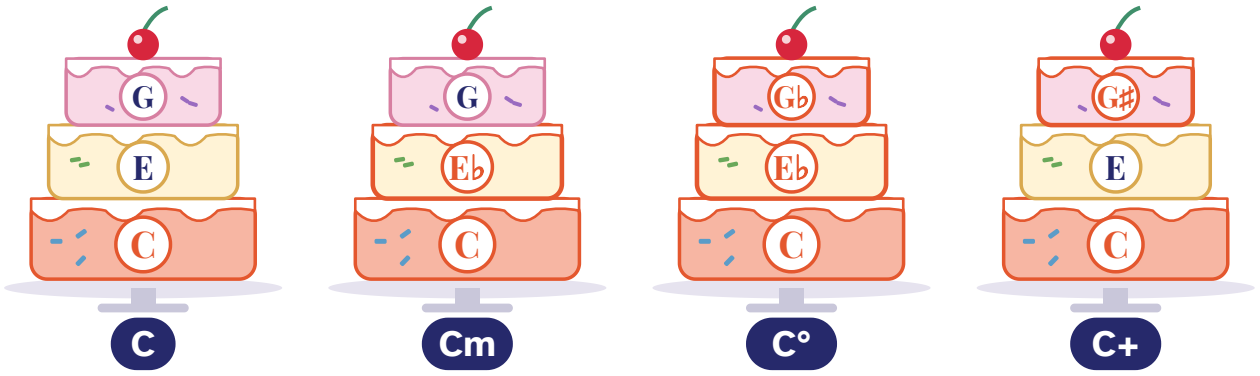
PART IV · CHORDS · 2

Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.

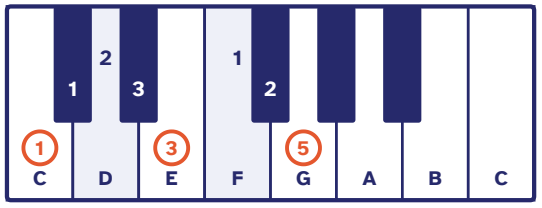


Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor

KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	CHORD NAME	FIRST MET
major	**3 + 2**	C E G	C	Level ½
minor	**2 + 3**	C E♭ G	Cm	Level 2
diminished	**2 + 2**	C E♭ G♭	C° or Cdim	Level 5
augmented	**3 + 3**	C E G♯	C+ or Caug	Level 6

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 41).

Count the keys in between



Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

The seven white-key triads, sorted



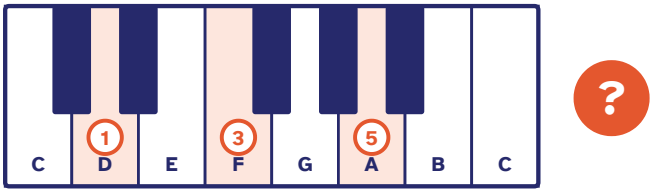
Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. Which ones belong to a key is the next chapter (p. 93).

How they sound

KIND	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
major	bright, settled, open	most cheerful tunes, fanfares
minor	darker, softer, sadder	lullabies, laments, film tension
diminished	tense, unstable, wants to move	suspense, spooky scenes
augmented	floating, dreamy, unsettled	dream scenes, a passing colour

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor? D F A

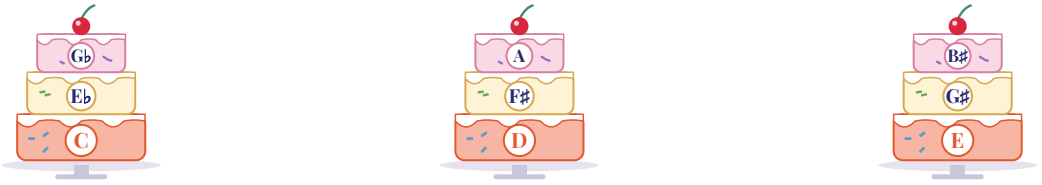


1. **Root to 3rd:** count the keys between D and F, black and white.
2. **3rd to 5th:** count the keys between F and A.
3. **3 + 2 or 2 + 3?**

D to F has 2 between, F to A has 3: **2 + 3**, so D F A is **D minor** (Dm).

GAME

Which kind?



1 2 3

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

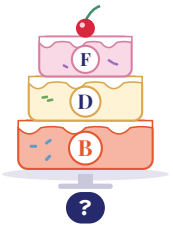


C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle layer moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

What kind is the triad on B?
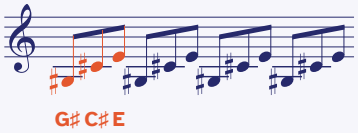


1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between** B and D, then D and F.
3. **Which kind has those two numbers?**

2 + 2: B D F is **B diminished** (B°), the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)



The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two gaps in the cake: a wide one (3 keys between) and a narrow one (2). Major: wide, then narrow, 3 + 2. Minor: narrow, then wide, 2 + 3. Diminished: two narrow, 2 + 2. Augmented: two wide, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 87 · Major, minor and perfect p. 41

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 2 · Online: Library › Chords